

LADIES' DAY CM Chouhan and BJP president Nadda with SHG members in Dewas

MADHYA PRADESH

WOOING WOMEN

By Rahul Noronha

First in Bihar and now in Uttar Pradesh, Prime Minister Narendra Modi cannot stop thanking those he calls the 'silent voters', namely the women in the electorate, who have been the direct beneficiaries of several central government schemes and have expressed their gratitude with their vote for the BJP. Increasingly aware of the importance of this demographic, the BJP is now openly wooing it. And what better way to consolidate the female vote than to fortify the state-sponsored self-help groups (SHGs), which have played a seminal role in empowering women in the countryside?

And so it was that BJP president J.P. Nadda found himself addressing a sea of women in red, blue and pink saris this International Women's Day on March 8 in Dewas in Madhya Pradesh. Making full use of the occasion, Nadda reiterated the Centre's pro-women schemes and lauded the MP government's implementation of these programmes.

MP's brigade of 'Didis' (so rechristened after Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan insisted that the earlier term 'bai' was demeaning) or women SHGs are a captive audience for the BJP. India has about 7.4 million SHGs, which bring together some 80 million women. MP has in recent years seen a huge jump in the number of all-women SHGs in its rural areas, from almost none in 2012 to about 357,499 today, spread across 45,527 of the state's 51,527 villages. Their members represent roughly 4 million of the state's families, which means they directly and indirectly impact about 20 million of the state's 87 million-strong population (assuming an average of five members per family). And hence the BJP's outreach.

"SHG functions are organised by the government," says Sachin Jain of Vikas Samvad, a social organisation working in MP, "but the guests are always BJP functionaries. Once a link between the functionary and government support to the SHG is established, the functionary has a greater 'acceptability' among beneficiaries. It is all very well thought out." And nothing translates better into votes than direct cash transfers. "Directly putting money into the hands of beneficiaries influences voting much more than making a road or digging a well," says Jain. "Financial independence also finally puts women in decision-making roles."

MP HAS 357,499 ALL-WOMEN RURAL SHGs, SPREAD ACROSS 45,527 OF ITS 51,527 VILLAGES

Political analyst Girija Shankar too is convinced that the BJP is betting on this model for the election in the state in 2023. "There is a belief within the BJP that its *laabharthi* (beneficiary-driven) approach has yielded rich dividends," he says. "The UP election, in which ration distribution was used to seek votes, has reinforced this belief." He does say for these schemes to turn into political profit, a lot depends on the efficient delivery of their benefits, the onus of which will lie with the Chouhan government.

To put more money directly into the hands of beneficiaries, the state government is handing over the implementation of some big-ticket public projects to SHGs. For example, the state's nutrition programme—allocated Rs 800 crore a year and managed by the state's women and child development department—is slowly being handed over to SHGs. They are also being permitted to operate in income-generating sectors such as wheat procurement and operation of ration shops. "Six plants to make take-home rations, each with 2,500 tonne capacity, have already been [given to] SHGs. The focus is now on building up their entrepreneurial capacity, since they are making a diverse product range but need marketing support," says L.M. Belwal, CEO of the MP Rural Livelihood Mission.

The state also claims it is strengthening SHGs by improving their access to credit, with Rs 2,900 crore worth of loans disbursed to about 320,000 groups. Funds to these groups have been allocated in other ways too, such as a Rs 286 crore 'revolving fund' for some 229,000 SHGs and Rs 834.42 crore as community investment to benefit about 106,000 groups. The state's current budget too saw a hike in allocation to SHGs, from Rs 600 crore to Rs 1,100 crore. Question is: will all the investment pay off in 2023? ■